regularized rent and taxes, and imposed fines on collectors who took more than was due. ‘Consideration should be shown in the exaction of dues,’ read the third ordinance; an increase in cultivated land was to be encouraged and ‘destitute farmers’ assisted with loans. Tax collectors were also to appoint ‘trustworthy and rightly-acting’ clerks, instead of the usual ‘corrupt’ fellows who worked ‘in collusion with the village head man, and . . . oppressed the peasantry’. Currency was to be regularized, farmers were to get receipts, and surveyors and their scribes to receive fixed salaries. Thus, as one of the ordinances concluded, ‘the country might soon be cultivated, the peasantry satisfied, and the treasury replenished’.[29]

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The relief of his subjects was not a passing fancy of Akbar’s. According to Abul Fazl, his very first orders as a newly crowned thirteen-year-old included the ‘remission of taxes’. It is more than possible, of course, that the historian is inventing this legislation; no taxpayer at the time would have known, or cared, about an adolescent putting on a crown in the fields of Kalanaur. Indeed, Abul Fazl, who never lets his ideals drown his facts, admits that ‘for some time [the rebate] was not carried into effect’.[30] The point of mentioning the order, articulated or not, executed or not, wasn’t to record history so much as to underline an intention. The happiness and prosperity of his subjects, that is, was the first principle of Akbar’s reign.

It wasn’t long, in fact, before Akbar did abolish some taxes. In the eighth and ninth years of his rule, between 1563 and 1564, he got rid of a tax levied on pilgrims, and then, more famously, the jizya. It wasn’t very long since Akbar had married Harkha Bai, in the early months of 1562. His first Rajput and Hindu queen, or her clan, may well have influenced his decision to rescind these ‘Hindu’ taxes – both the pilgrim tax and the jizya applied to non-Muslims in the realm.[31]

It may also be, of course, that the chronology is as much coincidence as cause. The historians J.S. Hoyland and S.N. Banerjee, writing about Akbar’s interest in religious discourse, relate how he visited the third Sikh Guru, Amar Das, ‘dined with him, and received a dress of honour’. Afterwards, some brahmins in Akbar’s court complained of how Sikhism – a new religion and one of many reformist movements to have developed